

SuSE Linux Office Desktop: The chameleon does it again



SuSE are trying to break up their Linux distros into two distinct categories; one targeted at



the general user and the other targeted at the office user. This is much better than trying to satisfy the needs of all the users in a single distribution.

The installer interface is very simple for those who have had some previous experience with SuSE, but for a newbie it can get confusing—SuSE does not follow the step-by-step installation process that is commonly used by all the other distros. Instead it uses a Web page format—all the detected settings are displayed on a single screen. To change any of the settings, you have to click on the specific item. The problem with this kind of installation is that you might miss out some important settings that should have been changed. Otherwise the install is perfect—the default option provided in the installation, mounted all the existing Windows partitions by itself.

The hardware support was quite amazing; it didn't have problems installing on any of the testbeds. Also, apart from the bundled StarOffice 6.0, it comes with Crossover, which lets you run many Windows-based applications on Linux.

Compatibility with rpm packages was not a problem. But the most annoying part was the absence of the 'make' utility needed for compiling from source. While the novice user might not consider this a shortcoming, users are not novices forever. Just as normal Windows users turn into power users after a few months of usage, Linux users generally demand much more from their distributions after a few months. This could be something as simple as compiling the open source alternative to MSN messenger (amsn).

Mandrake Linux 9.1 Standard review: A magician without a wand

Installing Mandrake is quite simple. The installer is very user-friendly, and even a newbie won't have a problem when selecting options. The disk partitioning

utility is slightly different from other distros. It is much more graphical and gives a multi-coloured view of the different partitions on your drive.

Mandrake 9.1 Standard comes with both Koffice 1.2.1 and OpenOffice 1.0.2, but StarOffice 6.0 comes only in the PowerPack edition. It comes with a whole lot of applications neatly grouped under various easy-to-understand categories such as Office, Networking, etc.



The Mandrake Control Centre is an excellent tool that lets you control all the hardware and software on your computer. The Software Sources Manager uses the CDs to manage the update process by default. It also lets you add extra sites for downloading the security updates. It lets you choose from a list of mirror sites. After configuring the proxy setting the updates work perfectly, but the list of sites is restricted. The updates take about 10 minutes to download on a T1 line.

The Windows partitions are mounted by default, but the user has to have prior knowledge of the mount points to access the partitions. The samba server management using the Mandrake Control Centre leaves much to be desired. It searches for servers on the network and lists all the available computers, but does not group them by workgroups. Moreover it has problems accessing Windows XP shares. Finally, you end up using the command line samba utilities to get your work done faster.

Overall Mandrake 9.1 is a good product but a little more effort is required to make it more user-friendly. While the operating system comes with a whole lot of goodies, it does not offer anything special for the typical office desktop user.

What it all means

In the Office desktop category SuSE Office Desktop outperformed all the others simply because it has been specifically developed for this particular segment. While the other distros (Redhat and Mandrake) are one-size-fits-all packages, SuSE has smartly moved away from this mentality and started addressing the needs of different target audiences. However, as far as pricing goes, Red Hat is the best option as it is freely downloadable, even for commercial use.

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